

AMD's Personal Internet Communicator (PIC), which was launched in October, deserves special mention.

"The PIC is designed to be an easy-to-use, affordable consumer device that provides managed internet connectivity and basic computing and Internet capabilities such as a browser, e-mail, office tools, and the ability to view images, multimedia files and standard format documents," AMD's Sanjeev Keskar says.

The PIC, bundled with Internet services, will be sold to VSNL's broadband users at between Rs 300 to Rs 1,000 per month, depending on the service. VSNL aims to have two million PIC users in India over the next two years, according to Shashi Kalathil, head of the broadband business of VSNL.

The Affordable Computing Initiative

Pradhan says that the "affordable computing solutions lab," which got inaugurated in IIT-Bombay in April, is a first step towards the goal of an affordable PC.

Sixty computers of various configurations have been set up at the lab. These can be used by anyone who wants to test their software functionality and hardware requirements. Pradhan's next goal is to build links and similar centres with other IITs.

If his plans materialise, there will be around 30 such labs across India. "We would like the IITs to give a third-party, honest opinion." This plan, said Pradhan, could cost "\$1 or 2 million" (Rs 4.5

“People need to get away from the ‘GHz concept.’ Indeed, Intel dropped the 4 GHz platform

Ravi Pradhan,
Country Manager-India,
Via Technologies

to 9 crore) and take up to two years to implement.

Pradhan is confident that India, where the market is as price-sensitive as it is, would do well to avoid the herd-mentality of getting the fastest and latest processors for tasks that do not require them, such as office applications.

"People say lowering the cost of computers (to Rs 15,000) is achievable in the next two years. Actually that's not true. It's here today," he says.

Each computer—with an 800 MHz processor, 128 megabytes of RAM, a CD-ROM drive, a floppy drive, a 20 GB hard disk, an internal modem, keyboard, mouse and monitor—costs Rs 15,000 plus taxes.

What Microsoft And Intel Are Doing

Rishi Srivastav, Business Group Lead, Windows Client, Microsoft India, has this to say about reaching out to those on the other side of the Divide: "PC penetration in India is less than 2 percent. We are working closely with Government with the mission of enabling digital inclusion and IT opportunity. For instance, with Windows XP Starter edition, we are working with various state governments on the People's PC program aimed at bridging the digital divide among people in Indian states through various campaigns, which would encourage larger penetration of PC in the home segment."

About the \$100 PC, Srivastav says, "Microsoft is committed to reach out to governments and geographies with the mission of enabling digital inclusion and IT opportunity. As evidenced by our recent launch of Windows XP Starter Edition and other digital inclusion initiatives such as the Local Language Program, Partners in Learning and Unlimited Potential, we will continue to explore solutions with government and technology partners to enable digital inclusion and create local social and economic opportunity."

Microsoft and Intel have for long been attracted by the prospect of the 300 million new users who will buy PCs in the next five years—most of them in countries not on the developed-countries list, such as China and India.

Intel has been quietly trying out a small, low-cost motherboard with an embedded Celeron CPU. The platform has been code-named "Shelton." Although there have been no official announcements, Shelton has already found its way into products in China.

In The Years To Come

We asked Noronha of bytesforall.org what he thinks the scene will be like a couple of years from now. Will people be buying computers more appropriate to their usage patterns? Will wastage reduce? Will PCs really empower the masses? What will the landscape be like, in general?

Noronha is pessimistic. "More PCs, more power, more PCs in junkyards, more people without access to them, more talk about lower prices, and yet IT going increasingly out of the reach of the common man—especially in the poorer parts of the globe—and the grossly inefficient use of a powerful tool. Sad, but we see little evidence that things are changing for the better. It's mostly a business-as-usual attitude." ☒

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